interviewed twice. During the interviews, he has shown tremendous vision and maturity which will be in line with the Tata Group's institutional culture.' With this, the issue of succession in Tata Sons was all but formally settled.

The committee also recorded that it was 'unable to identify any suitable candidate in India outside the Group'. The other candidates from within the group, though otherwise eligible, were of an age 'where longer-term continuity would not be possible'.

Ratan approved the recommendation. He sent a note along with the approval, making two observations. The first was that Mistry, who was the MD of the Shapoorji Pallonji Group—with interests in similar areas to the Tatas such as construction, real estate, textiles, engineering goods, home appliances, shipping, biotechnology, power and publications—should sever all relations with the company. Ratan explained that by severance, he meant creating a separation that would be 'legal and tenable'. The second was that for a year, Mistry would do 'parallel running' with Ratan to ensure that he got insights and hands-on experience on how to run the Tata Group.

With the approval accorded by Ratan, in December 2012, *The New York Times* commented that Mistry, who was 'not widely known even among close watchers of corporate India', was all set to be 'instantly' catapulted 'from a relatively little-known executive to the head of a sprawling global empire'. Many Tata veterans too expressed astonishment at the selection. Syamal Gupta, Ratan's close confidant, says that he could not comprehend why Mistry was selected in the first place.

N.P. Sinha, who had retired as vice president of Tata Steel, says, 'His appointment itself I would not have done.' Back in the day, J.R.D. Tata had been upset that his siblings had sold their shares of the Tata Group to Mistry's family. Under these circumstances, there should have been an awareness that sooner or later, there could be a clash of interests, Sinha felt.

J.J. Irani too was unhappy with the choice. To him, the Pallonji family's intentions seemed far from sanguine. He remarked that the manner in which Mistry's father Pallonji had gone about acquiring the Tata shares from JRD's siblings was 'despicable'. It was done in a way that 'disappointed' and 'disgusted' JRD. JRD 'never forgave him [Pallonji]', Irani elaborated.

Ratan, on the other hand, refused to let such factors influence his decision. He approved the recommendation and extended all support to his to-be successor. He said that he wanted Mistry to truly succeed and take the